

That, which, and extra information

Teaching guide

Show whether a relative clause identifies something or adds a detail.

Understand the distinction

A defining relative clause identifies the noun: The bike that has a red seat is mine. For things, that and which can both introduce defining clauses, though some style guides prefer that.

A non-defining clause adds extra information and uses commas: My bike, which has a red seat, is outside. Use which, not that, for this extra-information pattern. For people, who is often appropriate. Meaning decides whether the information is defining.

Compare the patterns

IDENTIFY

The report that arrived today is final.

This identifies which report.

ADD A DETAIL

The report, which arrived today, is final.

The report is already identified.

PEOPLE

The colleague who helped me is here.

Who refers to a person.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Choose for extra information: My laptop, ___ is new, works well.

- A. that
- B. what
- C. which

2. Can which introduce a defining clause about a thing?

- A. Yes, although some style guides prefer that.
- B. Yes, but every defining which clause needs commas.
- C. No. Which is restricted to extra information in every variety of English.

3. Choose the punctuation for extra information: Our office which opened in May is nearby.

- A. Our office, which opened in May is nearby.
- B. Our office, which opened in May, is nearby.
- C. Our office which opened in May, is nearby.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. The green label is extra information about your bag. Which version shows this correctly?

- A. My bag, which has a green label is under the chair.
- B. My bag, what has a green label, is under the chair.
- C. My bag, which has a green label, is under the chair.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. C. which

A non-defining clause uses which for things.

A: Use which for this extra-information clause set off by commas.

B: What does not replace which after the noun my laptop here.

2. A. Yes, although some style guides prefer that.

Do not mark all defining uses of which as ungrammatical.

B: Commas mark extra information; a defining clause normally has no commas.

C: Which can also introduce a defining clause, especially in British English.

3. B. Our office, which opened in May, is nearby.

The commas mark the additional detail.

A: Close the extra-information clause with a comma after May.

C: Use a comma on both sides of the extra-information clause.

4. C. My bag, which has a green label, is under the chair.

Which introduces the extra information, enclosed by two commas.

A: Add a closing comma after label.

B: Use which, not what, after the noun my bag.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-12.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

The green label is extra information about your bag. Which version shows this correctly?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.